

How to make a motion backdrop

One still picture, a layer of moving light drawn over it, and a single file that runs with no internet. Built for a stage where the wifi cannot be trusted.

01 The scene

One backdrop per act. Ask the person who will stand in front of it.

- One scene per song, speech or act. Write it in plain words. A village square at morning. A courtyard with a red flowering tree.
- Three rules that never bend: no people, no text baked into the picture, and not busy. A performer stands in front of this.
- Measure the screen before you generate anything. A normal projector is 16:9. A stage LED wall can be 20 ft by 7 ft, which is far wider.
- Build the page to fill and crop, never to letterbox. Then one wide picture serves both screens.

02 The still

One image from any image model. This is a photograph, not a video.

- Prompt shape that worked every time: the scene, then cinematic wide establishing shot, painterly matte painting, warm, no people, no text, 16:9, ultra high resolution.
- Ask for symmetry. A path or a doorway down the centre gives the performer somewhere to stand and reads clean from the back row.
- Regenerate, do not repair. A busy or lettered or off centre picture is cheaper to redo than to fix.
- A paid model is not required. Of the 8 backdrops on the live page, one was made free in a browser.

03 The motion

A transparent layer sits over the still and redraws itself every frame.

- The layer is a canvas, a blank surface in a web page that code can paint on. The picture underneath is never touched.
- 9 effects cover every scene: god rays, fireflies, dust, petals, sparkle, clouds, a drifting sweep of light, a pulsing glow, and lantern points.
- Each one is 3 numbers. How many, what colour, how bright. That is the whole of tuning a scene.
- Use a GIF only for hard edged shapes, like birds. Wind and clouds were tried as GIFs and looked wrong, because the format cuts soft edges flat.

04 The one file

On the night, nothing may depend on the venue.

- Every image is embedded into the page as text. The result is one file of roughly 6 MB with zero links to anything outside it.
- Double click it. Press F for fullscreen. Arrow keys or a number key jump between scenes, with a 1.1 second crossfade.

- Two keys the operator actually needs: B blacks the screen between acts, H hides every control.
- No venue wifi, no login, no app to install. Fully offline is the entire reason for building it this way.

WHAT IT CAN AND CANNOT DO

The light moves. The picture does not.

Rays, dust, petals and glow sit over a still, so a flag will not wave and water will not run. Pick calm scenes and the limit never shows. Pick a busy one and no amount of motion will save it.

SOURCES & NOTE

Sources: Live example, 8 backdrops: mannp09.github.io/fablewick/backdrops.html, verified serving August 31st 2026; Method, effect list and controls read from that page's own build record, July 2026; File size and self containment measured from the published file, not recalled.

The backdrops are generated pictures, not photographs of a real place. Say so if anyone asks. The motion is drawn by the browser, so test on the machine that will run the show, not the one that built it.

Glossary

Backdrop The image behind a stage. Here it fills the whole screen.

Still A single picture that does not move. The base of every scene.

Canvas A blank layer in a web page that code can draw on, frame by frame.

God rays Visible shafts of light angling down through air.

Sweep A soft band of light drifting across the frame, like a gust catching sun.

Crossfade One image fading out as the next fades in. 1.1 seconds here.

Matte painting A painted scene used as a background. The prompt word that keeps a picture calm.

16:9 Width to height. A normal projector. A stage LED wall is much wider.

Fill and crop Scale a picture until it covers the screen and let the overflow go.

Embed Write an image into the page itself as text, so the page needs no other files.

Offline Runs with no internet. The reason for embedding.

GIF An old moving image format. Only good here for hard edged shapes.